ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

LIN 101: Introduction to Linguistics - Sound, Structure and Meaning

Analyse language systematically instead of judging it

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
Linguistics | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Linguistics is descriptive, not prescriptive. This pack introduces phonetics and phonology, morphology, syntax, semantics and sociolinguistics, using Nigerian languages and Nigerian English as data - so the examples are close to what you actually hear.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Transcribe simple words using IPA.
- Identify morphemes and word-formation processes.
- Draw a basic syntactic tree.
- Explain the difference between descriptive and prescriptive approaches.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Phonetics and phonology

Sounds first, then the systems they form.

- Articulation: place and manner of consonants, voicing.
- Vowels described by height, backness and rounding.
- IPA symbols for sounds that English spelling hides.
- Phoneme versus allophone: contrast versus variation.
- Syllable structure, stress and tone.
- Nigerian languages contribute sounds English lacks; use them as data.

Morphology and syntax

Structure at word level and sentence level.

- Morpheme: free and bound; root, stem and affix.
- Word formation: derivation, compounding, borrowing, reduplication, clipping.
- Word classes identified by distribution, not only meaning.
- Constituents and phrase structure.
- Basic tree diagrams for simple sentences.
- Grammaticality is judged against a grammar, not against taste.

> **Describe, do not scold**
> 'Ain't' and Nigerian English forms are data about rules in use. Prescriptivism belongs to style guidance, not linguistic analysis.

Semantics and sociolinguistics

Meaning and social life are part of language structure.

- Sense, reference and ambiguity.
- Synonymy, antonymy, hyponymy and entailment.
- Pragmatics: implicature and speech acts.
- Variation by region, class, gender and context.
- Code-switching and multilingual repertoires.
- Language contact, pidginisation and creolisation.

Language as a system, not a list of rules

Linguistics studies language as a natural object. Its central claim is that every human language is a structured system with levels that can be analysed separately: phonetics (the sounds themselves), phonology (how sounds pattern), morphology (how words are built), syntax (how sentences are built), semantics (meaning) and pragmatics (meaning in use).

The discipline is descriptive, not prescriptive. A linguist does not ask whether "I no go school" is correct English but what system produces it and who uses it with whom. Judgements about correctness are social facts worth studying, but they are not linguistic analysis.

Descriptivism does not mean anything goes. Every language, dialect and pidgin has systematic rules, and a speaker who breaks them produces something that other speakers recognise as wrong. The difference between "he don go" and "he dey go" is grammatical, not a matter of taste.

Phonetics and phonology: the sounds and the patterns

Phonetics describes speech sounds by how they are produced: place of articulation (where the airflow is obstructed), manner (how it is obstructed) and voicing (whether the vocal folds vibrate). /p/ and /b/ share a place and manner and differ only in voicing, which is why they form a minimal pair in English: pin and bin.

Phonology studies which distinctions a particular language uses. English does not use aspiration to distinguish words, so the p in pin and the p in spin are heard as the same phoneme; many Indian languages do use it, so the two are different phonemes there. The phoneme is an abstract category, realised by different phones in different environments.

Nigerian languages contribute materially to this field. Igbo is tonal: pitch distinguishes words, so the same consonant-vowel sequence with a different tone is a different word. Yoruba has a complex tone system with three levels and, in some analyses, contour tones. Hausa has implosives and ejectives that English lacks. A student who learns to hear tone stops mis-hearing Igbo and Yoruba as "flat".

> **Minimal pairs are your test**
> If two words differ only by one sound and have different meanings, those sounds are separate phonemes in that language. This one test will carry you through most phonology questions.

Morphology and syntax: building words and sentences

Morphemes are the smallest units of meaning. "Unhelpfulness" contains un- (negation), help (root), -ful (adjective-forming), -ness (noun-forming). Free morphemes stand alone; bound morphemes attach. Inflectional morphology marks grammatical information without changing the word class (walk, walks, walked); derivational morphology changes the class or meaning (help, helpful, helper).

Syntax describes how words combine into phrases and sentences. Constituency tests - substitution, movement, coordination - show which words group together. A tree diagram is not decoration: it displays claims about structure that can be argued for.

Word order is not universal. English is SVO; many Nigerian languages are also SVO but differ in agreement, serial verb constructions and the position of the noun phrase. A key concept is agreement: in Igbo and Yoruba, verbs typically do not inflect for person the way English does, which is one reason Nigerian English sometimes regularises verb forms.

Sociolinguistics and language in Nigeria

Nigeria is one of the most linguistically diverse countries in the world, with over five hundred languages. Multilingualism is the norm: a student may speak a home language, a community lingua franca, Nigerian Pidgin, English and Arabic for religious purposes, each in a different domain.

Code-switching - alternating languages within a conversation - is a skilled practice, not confusion. It signals identity, manages relationships and marks topic shifts. Language attitudes, meanwhile, do real damage: children punished for speaking their mother tongue at school, speakers of minority languages shifting to dominant ones, and the prestige hierarchy that treats a foreign accent as competence.

Language policy is therefore a political question. Nigeria's National Policy on Education recommends mother-tongue instruction in early primary school, but implementation varies; the result is measurable in language shift and in literacy outcomes.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Doing a phonemic analysis

You are given a short word list from an unfamiliar language and asked which sounds are contrastive.

1. Look for pairs of words that differ in exactly one sound.
2. Check that the meanings differ; if so, you have a minimal pair.
3. Name the two sounds as separate phonemes and write them between slashes.
4. Where no minimal pair exists, check whether the two sounds occur in complementary environments - if so, they may be allophones of one phoneme.
5. State your conclusion with the evidence, and note any ambiguity.

> **What to carry forward**
> Minimal pair first, complementary distribution second, conclusion with evidence always.

2. Morphological parsing

Break "disrespectfully" into morphemes and classify each.

1. Identify the root: respect.
2. Attach the prefix dis- (negation, derivational).
3. Attach -ful (derivational, noun to adjective).
4. Attach -ly (derivational, adjective to adverb).
5. Check: is the order fixed? Yes - dis + respect + ful + ly, and reversing any pair produces a non-word.
6. Express the structure as a bracketed tree rather than a flat list.

> **What to carry forward**
> Show the structure. A flat list of morphemes does not demonstrate understanding of hierarchy.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Distinguish phonetics from phonology with examples from a Nigerian language.

15 marks

1. Phonetics: physical production and perception of sounds.
2. Phonology: how a language organises sounds into contrastive categories.
3. Use tone in Igbo or Yoruba: phonetically a pitch difference, phonologically a meaning distinction.
4. Conclude that the same physical fact can be contrastive in one language and not another.

Q2. Why is linguistics descriptive rather than prescriptive?

10 marks

1. Define both positions.
2. State that all varieties are systematic.
3. Distinguish grammaticality from social acceptability.
4. Note that prescriptivism is itself a legitimate object of study.

Q3. Explain code-switching as a skilled practice, using a Nigerian example.

15 marks

1. Define code-switching and distinguish it from borrowing and from interlanguage.
2. Give a domain example: home language in family talk, Pidgin with peers, English in class.
3. Explain the functions: identity, solidarity, topic marking, quotation.
4. Refute the "confusion" interpretation with evidence of systematicity.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Equating code-switching with poor competence in one language.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Phoneme. A contrastive sound unit in a language, written between slashes.

Allophone. A variant pronunciation of a phoneme in a particular environment.

Minimal pair. Two words differing by one sound and differing in meaning.

Morpheme. The smallest unit of meaning in a word.

Derivational morpheme. An affix that changes a word's class or meaning.

Inflectional morpheme. An affix marking grammatical information without changing class.

Syntax. The rules governing how words combine into phrases and sentences.

Constituent. A group of words functioning as a unit within a larger structure.

Tone. Use of pitch to distinguish word meaning, as in Igbo and Yoruba.

Pragmatics. The study of meaning as shaped by context and use.

Code-switching. Alternating between languages within a conversation or utterance.

Lingua franca. A language used for communication between speakers of different first languages.

Language shift. A community's gradual replacement of one language by another.

Descriptivism. The approach of analysing language as it is used rather than prescribing usage.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Sounds

Phonetics.

- Learn the IPA symbols for English consonants.
- Describe five sounds by place, manner and voicing.
- Transcribe ten words.

Week 2 - Patterns

Phonology.

- Find five minimal pairs in English.
- Identify tonal minimal pairs in Igbo or Yoruba.
- Explain allophones in one environment.

Week 3 - Structure

Morphology and syntax.

- Parse ten words into morphemes.
- Draw three tree diagrams.
- Apply two constituency tests.

Week 4 - Society

Sociolinguistics.

- Record a code-switching example with permission.
- Classify its functions.
- Write a 15-mark timed answer.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Any introductory linguistics textbook covering phonetics, morphology and syntax.
- An introduction to the linguistics of Nigerian languages.
- A sociolinguistics reader with African case studies.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Distinguish a phoneme from an allophone.

Answer: A phoneme contrasts meaning in a language; an allophone is a variant pronunciation of the same phoneme in a context.

2. What is a bound morpheme?

Answer: A morpheme that cannot stand alone and must attach to another form, such as a plural or tense marker.

3. Why is prescriptivism not linguistic analysis?

Answer: It evaluates usage against a preferred standard rather than describing the rules speakers actually follow.

4. Give an example of code-switching.

Answer: Alternating between Igbo and English within a conversation or sentence according to topic, interlocutor or setting.

5. What does a constituency test show?

Answer: Which groups of words behave as a single structural unit in a sentence.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Learn the IPA symbols used in your course.
- [ ] Transcribe twenty words from two languages.
- [ ] Segment ten words into morphemes.
- [ ] Draw five simple tree diagrams.
- [ ] Collect three examples of code-switching you observe.
- [ ] Read one paper on Nigerian English.
- [ ] Write a short descriptive analysis with data, not opinion.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

> **More from the ZikShare Academic Vault**
> Find faculty primers, study-skills guides, money and career packs, and digital-skills workbooks in the ZikShare Library. New packs are added every semester.

ZikShare Academic Vault | Faculty Primer | 100L | 2026 Fresher Edition

YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

LIN 101: Introduction to Linguistics - Sound, Structure and Meaning